



ISAAC B. "ZAC" BEARS
President

City of Medford

OFFICE OF THE CITY COUNCIL

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To: Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn
From: City Council President Isaac B. "Zac" Bears
Date: March 31, 2026
Re: City Council FY27 Budget Recommendations

Dear Mayor Lungo-Koehn,

Thank you for the work of our city team on the FY27 budget process. I appreciate that several Council recommendations for the FY26 budget were funded in this fiscal year, including the Linkage Fee Study and the initiation of the updates to the City's Financial Software.

Below are the collective recommendations of the City Council to include in the Fiscal Year 2027 City Budget as approved at our March 24, 2026 Regular Meeting. Additionally, I have attached the individual recommendations of councilors as a separate PDF document. We look forward to working with you and your team to include these recommendations in the budget this year.

Level-Service Budget for Medford Public Schools and City Departments

1. Maintain Level-Service Funding for MPS and City Departments

- a. Meet the School Committee's budget request for the Medford Public Schools and the Board of Library Trustees' request for the Medford Public Library
- b. For city departments, Councilors identified specific focuses on the Community Liaisons Program, Translation Services, Mental Health Services, Rodent Control, and All Grant Funded Positions in PDS and Health Departments
- c. **Estimated Impact: TBD based on Preliminary Budget Meetings**

New Ongoing Expenditures

2. Increase Funding for Assessing Department to Implement Residential Exemption

- a. The Council has voted to pursue a Residential Exemption for the FY27 tax year and the Assessing Department has indicated that 1 to 2 additional full-time staff members would be necessary to process exemption applications.
- b. These staff members could also assist residents who are applying for other exemptions, such as seniors and veterans.
- c. **Estimated Impact: \$100,000 to \$200,000**

3. Fund Medford Family Network to Prevent Cuts

- a. Provide city funding to the Medford Family Network to ensure continued services and replace any funding that is being lost in FY27.
- b. **Estimated Impact: Up to \$300,000**

4. Approve Budget Reallocation for Updated City Messenger/Council Assistant Position

- a. Support the requested Legislative Department budget to fund the updated City Messenger/Council Assistant position outlined in the new City Charter approved by the voters in November 2025.
- b. **Estimated Impact: \$0 (reallocation of existing Legislative Department funds from FY26 ordinary budget to FY27 personnel budget)**

5. Increase Arts and Culture Funding/Support and Funding for Library Staff

- a. Provide additional funding for Medford Arts Council to support local arts organizations and create a timeline to re-establish a permanent city Arts and Culture staff position to support the arts community
- b. Increase pay for part-time librarians at the Medford Public Library to ensure fair wages and ensure positions are competitive with similar positions neighboring communities
- c. **Estimated Impact: Minimum \$100,000**

6. Increase Funding for DPW, Engineering, and Facilities Departments for Improved Street Repair and Safety, Tree Planting, and Capital Improvements

- a. Fund street repair and safety improvements building on the FY2026 recommendations of the Medford Bicycle Advisory Commission, including but not limited to:
 - i. Engineering staff focused on walking, biking, and transit to implement Vision Zero and Complete Streets
 - ii. Increase funding for DPW staff positions for restriping, adjusting signal timing, patching potholes, and shrinking repair backlog
 - iii. Budget to purchase install and maintain road safety markings, signage, and bike-related equipment
- b. Fund our Urban Tree Management Plan and enable volunteers to conduct the volunteer tree planting program, including a half-time DPW volunteer coordinator for a volunteer tree planting program
- c. Funds to improve snow removal work, including a city program to clear the list of priority sidewalks and bus stops developed by the Council and DPW in 2021
- d. **Estimated Impact: Minimum \$250,000**

7. Fund Therapeutic Recreation Specialist and Office Manager in Recreation Department and a Citywide Inclusion Specialist

- a. The Council has been working alongside residents with disabilities and their families to improve city services and inclusion across the city and community, which has identified these staffing needs.
- b. **Estimated Impact: \$200,000**

8. Fund Fire Department Dive Team Training and Equipment

- a. Given our extensive waterways, the Council believes it is a priority to add a dive team in the Fire Department. Councilor Lazzaro received the financial cost estimate during discussions with Fire Chief Evans.
- b. **Estimated Impact: \$122,933**

One-Time Expenses

9. Nexus Studies for Inclusionary Zoning and Transportation Demand Management

- a. Provide a written update on the Linkage Fee study, and whether that also serves as an economic impact nexus study that will allow us to update the inclusionary zoning and implement a Transportation Demand Management program
- b. If still needed, please fund the nexus economic impact studies that are necessary to update our key affordable housing and transportation programs
- c. This one-time cost could be funded by stabilization funds or free cash reserves.
- d. **Estimated Impact: \$100,000**

Sincerely yours,
Zac Bears

cc: Chief of Staff Nina Nazarian and Finance Director Bob Dickinson